

Gerrit Rietveld

Gerrit Rietveld (1888–1964) is remembered as much for his furniture as for his buildings; his simple chairs, now classics, were designed for mass production and affordability – ideas he would later carry into housing. Rietveld qualified as an architect in 1919 and joined De Stijl, a movement founded in 1917 by artists Piet Mondrian and Theo van Doesburg. De Stijl artists advocated pure abstraction: simplifying compositions to verticals and horizontals, and primary colours with black and white. In 1923, Gropius invited Rietveld to exhibit at the Bauhaus, the groundbreaking German school of arts and crafts, and in 1924 he designed the Schröder House in Utrecht (opposite), a 3D realization of a Mondrian painting. A blend of De Stijl and Bauhaus ideals, it comprises intersecting planes on the exterior and sliding walls inside to rearrange living spaces. In 1928, Rietveld broke with De Stijl in favour of a more functionalist architectural style, and in later decades pursued social housing projects, using inexpensive materials and innovative methods of prefabrication.

